

Traditional Seoul Village Hopes Curfew Brings Back Normal Life

In South Korea's capital of Seoul, Bukchon Hanok Village's narrow winding alleyways date back hundreds of years to the Joseon Dynasty. The area has become a popular place to visit, especially after appearing in a television show about 10 years ago.

Foreign visitors and Koreans visit the neighborhood to see houses with wood columns, courtyards and tiled roofs.

The area attracted about 6 million visitors last year while the population of the area is around 6,100.

However, increasing numbers of visitors have become a problem for people who live there. They complain about noise, trash, bad behavior and invasion of privacy.

Some visitors have been caught on camera trying to enter private homes or looking inside without permission, creating conflict with locals.

Many local people have chosen to leave, leading to a 27.6 percent drop in the village's population over the past 10 years.

Village officials now want to set a curfew in the area. The curfew will limit visitors to certain areas of Bukchon from 5 p.m. to 10 a.m. local time. It will start as a trial in November and will be officially launched next March. Violators could pay fines of up to \$72.

Chung Moon-hun is the head of Jongno district. Chung said the goal is to protect the rights of local people. Chung said the curfew can be changed if necessary to make it more effective. The area where curfew hours and fines will be in effect is about 34,000 square meters. That is about the size of five soccer fields.

Tourists gather and interact at Bukchon Hanok Village in Seoul, South Korea, October 20, 2024. (REUTERS/Kim Soo-hyeon)

Kwon Young-doo owns the private Asian Cultural Art Museum in Bukchon Hanok Village. Kwon is concerned about the curfew policy aimed at preventing visitors from overrunning the area.

"Who would want to visit?" asked Kwon who moved into the historic area 18 years ago. "They'll leave with a bad impression of South Korea."

Others do not believe the policy will be effective. They note measures such as exemptions for visitors staying overnight in traditional houses called hanok. Many of these hanok are now

owned by businesses after officials loosened restrictions on overnight stays.

"People come for just a day to enjoy themselves, and the noise from parties is extremely loud," said Kim Eun-mee, who lives next to a hanok. Clearing trash in front of her home has become a task she has to perform several times a day.

"It's often difficult to maintain a normal daily routine due to disturbances." She said people often make noise moving their suitcases around even in the early hours, which wakes her up.

Lee Dong-woo is head of the website BUTLER.LEE which is used to rent the hanoks. Lee said the business grew when owners who found it difficult to modernize or maintain old houses turned them over to businesses.

"These requests are driving the expansion, not because we are actively evicting current residents to operate hanok stays," Lee said. Lee oversees 17 hanok stays in Bukchon.

Visitors are divided over the curfew. Some agree locals' quality of life is important. Others are unhappy at the idea of getting fined for simply walking down a public street.

There are also questions about how the rules will be enforced; how to tell visitors from locals; how to make foreigners pay a fine, and how to deal with the language barrier.

I'm Mario Ritter Jr.

Reuters reported on this story. Hai Do adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

dynasty - n. ราชวงศ์, กลุ่มผู้ปกครองที่สืบทอดอำนาจต่อกันเป็นเวลานาน

column - n. เสา, โครงสร้างทรงกลมหรือสี่เหลี่ยมที่รองรับอาคาร

courtyard - n. ลานบ้าน, พื้นที่เปิดโล่งที่ล้อมรอบด้วยอาคาร

roof - n. หลังคา, ส่วนบนสุดของบ้านที่ปกป้องภายในจากฝนและแสงแดด

trash - n. ขยะ, วัสดุเหลือใช้หรือสิ่งที่ไม่ต้องการ

trial - n. การทดลอง, การทดสอบ

exemption - n. ข้อยกเว้น, การได้รับการปลดเปลื้องจากการต้องปฏิบัติตามกฎที่ผู้อื่นต้องทำ

routine - n. กิจวัตร, สิ่งที่ทำเป็นประจำตามปกติในแต่ละวันหรือสัปดาห์

disturbance - n. การรบกวน, เหตุการณ์ที่เสียงดัง น่าประหลาดใจ หรือทำให้ผู้คนต้องเปลี่ยนจากสิ่งที่ทำตามปกติ

evict - v. ขับไล่, การบังคับให้บุคคลออกจากสถานที่ที่พวกเขาอาศัยหรือพักอยู่ตามปกติ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What is a key reason for Bukchon Hanok Village's recent surge in popularity?

It was recently designated a UNESCO World Heritage site.

It appeared in a popular television show about 10 years ago.

It underwent extensive modernization to attract tourists.

It offers unique shopping opportunities not found elsewhere in Seoul.

2. What specific architectural characteristics attract visitors to Bukchon Hanok Village?

Glass skyscrapers and modern art installations.

Houses with wood columns, courtyards, and tiled roofs.

Underground tunnels and hidden passages.

Futuristic designs and eco-friendly structures.

3. Based on the text, what can be inferred about the scale of tourism relative to the local population in Bukchon Hanok Village?

The number of visitors is slightly less than the local population.

The local population significantly outnumbers the annual visitors.

Visitors greatly outnumber the local residents by a large margin.

There is an equal balance between visitors and residents.

4. Which of the following is NOT among the main complaints of local residents regarding the increasing number of visitors?

Noise pollution.

Lack of public transportation.

Trash accumulation.

Invasion of privacy.

5. What specific negative action by some visitors has directly led to conflict with Bukchon Hanok Village locals?

Refusing to pay for goods and services.

Blocking public pathways with large groups.

Attempting to enter private homes or looking inside without permission.

Leaving negative reviews on social media about the village.

6. What significant demographic change has occurred in Bukchon Hanok Village due to increasing visitor numbers?

The local population has grown by 27.6% over the past decade.

A large influx of new residents has moved into the village.

There has been a 27.6% drop in the village's population over the past 10 years.

The average age of residents has significantly decreased.

7. What are the key details of the curfew policy planned for Bukchon Hanok Village?

It will ban all visitors from the village from 5 p.m. to 10 a.m. starting next March, with no fines.

It will limit visitors to certain areas from 5 p.m. to 10 a.m., start as a trial in November, and officially launch next March with potential fines of up to \$72.

It will restrict visitor access only on weekends, with a trial period of one year.

It will only apply to foreign visitors, requiring them to register before 5 p.m.

8. According to Chung Moon-hun, the head of Jongno district, what is the primary objective of the new curfew policy?

To significantly increase tourism revenue for the district.

To modernize the village's infrastructure.

To protect the rights and quality of life of local people.

To promote traditional Korean culture to international visitors.

9. What is Kwon Young-doo's main concern regarding the curfew policy?

That it will make the village too quiet and less vibrant.

That it will deter visitors and leave them with a negative impression of South Korea.

That it will lead to an increase in property taxes for museum owners.

That it does not go far enough to protect residents' privacy.

10. Kwon Young-doo believes the curfew policy could lead to what negative consequence?

An increase in property value for local businesses.

A decline in the number of hanok stays available.

Visitors developing a bad impression of South Korea.

Improved relations between tourists and residents.

11. What factor is cited by some as a reason why the curfew policy might not be effective?

The fines are too low to be a deterrent.

The policy includes exemptions for visitors staying overnight in traditional hanok houses, which are increasingly business-owned.

The curfew hours are too short to make a significant difference.

Local officials do not have the authority to enforce such a policy.

12. What specific problem does Kim Eun-mee, a resident living next to a hanok, frequently face due to visitors?

Difficulty finding parking for her car.

Loud noise from parties and having to clear trash in front of her home multiple times a day.

Tourists constantly asking for directions to attractions.

Lack of fresh food markets in the neighborhood.

13. Besides party noise and trash, what other disturbance does Kim Eun-mee mention that disrupts her daily routine?

Construction work nearby.

Delivery trucks blocking the street.

People making noise moving their suitcases around in the early hours.

Children playing loudly in the evenings.

14. According to Lee Dong-woo, what primarily contributed to the growth of the hanok rental business?

Aggressive marketing campaigns by rental companies.

Government subsidies for hanok restoration.

Owners of old houses finding it difficult to modernize or maintain them, leading them to turn them over to businesses.

A sudden increase in foreign investment in the tourism sector.

15. What does Lee Dong-woo clarify about the expansion of hanok rental businesses?

The expansion is driven by government regulations on historic properties.

The business is actively evicting current residents to operate hanok stays.

The expansion is driven by requests from owners, not by actively evicting residents.

The hanok stays are primarily targeting local residents, not tourists.